of 'mutual concerns' such as 'terrorism', 'separatism', and 'religious extremism'.[163] But India (under Narayanan) didn't trust China on Afghanistan-Pakistan, and refused to engage.[164] Though having gained rights over the strategic Aynak copper mine in Afghanistan's Logar province, China was not interested in enhancing its political and security profile in the country.[165] But soon after, Beijing began to exert its influence on Pakistan as Afghanistan's security situation worsened (raising fears of unrest in China's Uighur-dominated Xinjiang province).[166] China had pronounced the 'one belt, one road' development strategy that entailed connecting Europe and China via the Middle East and Central Asia—and stability in Afghanistan was central for the strategy to succeed.[167] Within a couple of years, in May 2015, China facilitated secret talks between the Taliban and the Afghan government in the city of Urumqi (with Pakistan's officials as observers).[168] Interestingly, the spy agencies of Afghanistan and Pakistan, enemies for decades, signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) on intelligence sharing during these talks, sending a shock wave within and outside Afghanistan. In July of the same year, another round of talks took place in Murree (in Pakistan),[169] followed by the Doha Dialogue in January 2016, and creation of the quadrilateral coordination group (QCG) wherein the US, China, Pakistan, and Afghanistan engaged in dialogue to resolve bilateral differences between Afghanistan and Pakistan.[170]

Given India's concerns about China's growing regional influence, Beijing's entry into Afghan politics should have raised suspicions in India. The truth was far from it. China's entry had been made easy by the same vehicle of multilateral diplomacy that had taken shape in Harbin. India sought another RIC meeting in February 2013 to discuss the situation in Afghanistan. The aim was to isolate Pakistan and reduce its strategic value in Afghanistan—that received positive reception from Iran as well. Common ground between India, Russia, China and Iran coupled with a willing Washington meant that Pakistan's value would get confined to becoming a tactical catalyst in bringing the Taliban to the talking table. In this context, India began to view China's separate trilateral with Russia and Pakistan as a way to coerce or persuade Islamabad into 'convincing' the Taliban to engage in negotiations. Tight-lipped on the exact nature of India's collaboration with China on Afghanistan, Menon says: 'I don't think people talk